Rishika Mihani, CEO of Wolves International Real Estate. "Deals that were on hold are starting to move again, and buyers are coming back in."

NAVIGATING THE WAR

Dubai has announced a Dh1 billion ($272 million) support package, effective April 1, offering fee deferrals, rental support and targeted relief for businesses in tourism, logistics and aviation. The Central Bank has stepped in with liquidity measures to keep credit flowing. Some companies have moved to reassure employees. Emaar, builder of Burj Khalifa and Dubai Mall, has pledged no layoffs. Indian billionaire Rizwan Sajan, founder of Danube Group, has said more than 6,000 employees will continue to receive salaries on time. Businesses in other sectors are also holding the line. Alsayegh Worldwide, a UAE-based creative agency, says it will not cut jobs or salaries.

But such assurances are not universal. Thousands of expatriates in affected sectors face frozen salaries and shrinking bonuses. Money transfers to India, Pakistan and the Philippines—lifelines for families—have begun to falter. Construction workers, already on edge, are feeling the impact as projects slow. Ram Khilawan, a construction worker from Bihar, scrolls through the WhatsApp messages on his phone. "My family sees explosions on Indian television and thinks all of Dubai is burning," he says. "I keep telling them I'm safe."

THOUSANDS OF EXPATS IN AFFECTED SECTORS FACE FROZEN SALARIES. MONEY TRANSFERS TO INDIA, PAKISTAN AND THE PHILIPPINES HAVE BEGUN TO FALTER

At the same time, UAE leaders have also appeared in public to project calm. Last month, President Al Nahyan and Dubai Crown Prince Sheikh Hamdan bin Mohammed were seen interacting with residents at Dubai Mall, while Vice President and Prime Minister Sheikh Mohammed bin Rashid Al Maktoum made a similar public appearance elsewhere. Billboards for the 'Everyone is Emirati' campaign emphasise unity and shared belonging. "Dubai is home now," says Ejaz Ahmad, a tech professional from Hyderabad. "Every time an alert came or you heard a thud, it was unsettling, but there was no panic or fear. There's no shortage of fuel or basic supplies. Back home, even essential things like LPG and fuel can become uncertain. I'm not packing up." A British marketing consultant working in Media City is more direct. "Dubai gave us opportunities we couldn't find elsewhere—career growth, safety, quality of life. Walking away now feels like starting from zero," he says.

UNITED ARAB EMIRATES

LAND AREA 83,600 SQ. KM	**POPULATION** 10.99 MILLION
INDIAN EXPATRIATES 4.32 MILLION (44% of expats in the UAE)	**REMITTANCES TO INDIA** $22.8 BILLION (19.2% of total inflows)
GDP $552.3 BILLION	**OIL RENTS*** 15.7%

THE DAMAGE

NO. OF MISSILE/ DRONE ATTACKS 2,700+	**KILLED/ WOUNDED** 12/ 217
DROP IN OIL EXPORTS 60%	**GDP GROWTH DOWNGRADE** 2.7 % POINTS

KEY FACILITIES HIT

● Fujairah port & refinery ● Al Minhad & Al Dhafra airbases ● Dubai airport ● Jebel Ali port ● Units/ refineries of Abu Dhabi National Oil Company ● Ruwais Industrial Complex (Abu Dhabi) ● Khalifa Economic Zone (Abu Dhabi) ● Habshan & Ajban gas facilities

*economic surplus generated from oil production, as % of GDP

After the ceasefire was declared, UAE presidential advisor Gargash emphasised the need for a broader security framework, including safeguards for maritime navigation through the Strait of Hormuz. So far, the UAE has avoided direct military involvement while continuing to call for de-escalation and dialogue, and Gargash indicated that it is likely to continue on this path of restraint while relying on established security partnerships to maintain stability in a volatile region. At the same time, it is navigating a delicate balance. Its normalisation of ties with Israel under the Abraham Accords has brought economic and strategic gains but also requires careful handling in a region where public sentiment remains sensitive. The UAE's approach is pragmatic: maintain ties, avoid escalation and keep channels open.

Back in Al Barsha, Babu watches the evening traffic thin. Dubai has weathered financial crises, a pandemic and regional tensions before. This time, the shock feels closer and less predictable. Insurance markets remain jittery, and long-term investors cautious. For now, most residents are staying put—waiting, watching and hoping the calm holds. ■